MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

# Block 3 — Unit 4: The Kite Maker, Promotion and A Temporary Matter

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

## The chapter in one sentence

Three short stories reveal how small encounters expose ageing, caste hierarchy, economic aspiration, grief, and the fragility of intimacy.

## Start with a picture

A kite, an office task, and a scheduled power cut seem minor. Each becomes a way of seeing relationships that people ordinarily ignore or avoid naming.

## 1. Ruskin Bond: The Kite Maker

Mahmood’s craft connects him with an earlier social world in which kite flying carried communal and sometimes patronal importance. His relation with the child Ali gives the story an intimate link between generations.

Changing space and habits reduce the place available for the craft. Remembering is therefore both affection and evidence of social change. The story’s restraint makes the old man’s vulnerability visible without needing a grand heroic event.

Analyse the kite as a made object, the setting, the contrast between past and present, and the narrator’s handling of the ending. Do not reduce the story to a universal claim that every change is bad.

## 2. Arjun Dangle: Promotion

Waghmare has gained an official position, but a colleague’s refusal and the workplace’s caste relations make clear that promotion has not secured equal recognition. Institutional status and social power do not perfectly coincide.

At home, his attitude towards poorer relatives exposes another difficulty: status aspiration can weaken solidarity. His child’s experience brings discrimination back into the family’s supposedly protected space.

The story, read in English translation, examines caste through work, speech, access, and self-presentation. It does not claim that a victim’s identity causes oppression. Distinguish discriminatory institutions from the strategies people develop while navigating them.

## 3. Jhumpa Lahiri: A Temporary Matter

Shoba and Shukumar live with the grief of losing their baby. Scheduled evening power cuts provide a setting for sharing things they had not said. Darkness appears to make conversation possible, but disclosure does not guarantee repair.

Their memories and confessions expose different responses to the loss and growing distance within the marriage. Shoba’s plans and Shukumar’s final revelation change the meaning of the apparent intimacy.

The title joins a practical interruption with more lasting emotional damage. Use light, darkness, meals, domestic space, and the order of revelation to explain how the story produces its effect.

## 4. Compare short-story methods

Bond uses restrained observation and historical change. Dangle uses irony and a movement between office and home. Lahiri arranges a sequence of disclosures within repeated evening encounters. Each gives a small event a larger structure without needing the span of a long novel.

## Quick check

1. Does Waghmare’s promotion end caste discrimination? **No.**
2. Does conversation automatically reconcile the couple in Lahiri? **No.**
3. Is Mahmood’s craft merely a decorative hobby? **No; it connects personal memory with a changing social world.**

## Source title caution

One course assignment calls Bond’s story The Kite Runner. The prescribed story here is The Kite Maker; The Kite Runner is a different novel by Khaled Hosseini. Do not substitute that novel for this unit.

## Build an exam answer

1. Explain the relation between small incident and wider pressure.
2. Analyse craft and memory in Bond.
3. Discuss office/home irony in Dangle.
4. Trace light, darkness, and disclosure in Lahiri.
5. Compare the role of the ending in each story.

## Common mistake to avoid

Do not blame a marginalised identity for discrimination or mistake momentary openness in Lahiri for a settled happy ending.

## Developed exam discussion

### Practice question

How do the three stories use ordinary incidents to expose unequal or damaged relationships?

### Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The short-story form can make an ordinary incident carry a broad social pressure. The Kite Maker attaches changing communal life to a craftsman's memories and vulnerability. The particular object matters because it links skilled labour, pleasure, place, and a relationship between generations. Its significance would be lost in a summary that described only an old man's sadness.

Promotion makes an apparently routine office conflict reveal a gap between formal authority and caste power. The movement into Waghmare's home prevents the account from remaining a simple opposition between office victim and workplace oppressor. His treatment of poor relatives complicates status aspiration while the child's experience shows how discrimination continues across spaces.

A Temporary Matter gives repetition a different function. The power cuts create a ritual of disclosure, but each evening revises the reader's understanding of the intimacy being produced. Darkness enables speech without ensuring mutual repair. The final revelations make the title more than a reference to an electricity problem.

An effective comparison identifies these methods—object, irony, spatial movement, repetition, and withholding. The stories do not merely state social themes. They organise a reader's recognition of pressures that characters may minimise, misread, or struggle to express.

### Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

## Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Analyse the story "The Kite Maker" in the background of the current changes in the country by replacing the tradition with new ways of life.
2. How does the partition reflect the themes of Indian fiction? Discuss by analysing the story "The Kite Maker."
3. Write on the narrative qualities of Ruskin Bond after reading his story "The Kite Runner."
4. Bring out the symbolical elements discussed in the story The Kite Maker."
5. Discuss the plight of Dalits with reference to the story "Promotion" by Arjun Dangle.

6. Arjun Dangle’s short story “Promotion” offers an insightful look at the ambivalent crisis of identity in the Dalit middle class. Discuss.
7. Dalit narratives are already a predominant area in the vast realm of Indian English Literature. Discuss.
8. Discuss the view that communication plays a key role in fixing the bond in a relationship by referring to “A Temporary Matter” by Jhumpa Lahiri.
9. Analyse with your viewpoint the tragedy that occurred in the life of Shobha and Sukumar.
10. Explain the Diaspora literature by relating it to the Indian context.